

Mina Leal Birch

Senior Finance Leader | Financial Leadership | Finance Transformation | Change

Oxford | 07590 28 25 89 | minalealbirch@gmail.com | [LinkedIn](#)

PROFILE

Senior finance professional with 20+ years of experience across higher education, financial services, charities, and commercial organisations. Proven track record of leading budgeting, forecasting, management reporting, controls, and financial planning across complex environments with significant income, payroll, and grant funding.

Known for improving finance operations, strengthening controls, and delivering clearer, faster management information to support better decision-making. Brings a practical and forward-thinking approach to finance transformation, including the use of generative AI to support analysis, training, stakeholder understanding, and scenario modelling.

A trusted partner to senior leaders and non-financial stakeholders, with strong experience in business partnering, process improvement, team leadership, and translating financial complexity into clear action. Fluent in English, Portuguese, and Spanish.

KEY CAPABILITIES

Core Expertise

Budgeting & Forecasting | Management Reporting | Variance Analysis | Business Partnering | Financial Modelling | Process Improvement | Internal Controls | Audit & Compliance | Finance Transformation | Payroll & FTE Analysis | Team Leadership

Systems & Digital Tools

Oracle R12 | SAP | Xero | QuickBooks | Sage | SplashBI | Microsoft 365 & Co-Pilot | Advanced Excel | ChatGPT | Claude | Generative AI for finance analysis, reporting and training

Languages

English (Professional) | Spanish (Professional) | Portuguese (Native)

EXPERIENCE

Senior Finance Manager | Clinical Neurosciences, University of Oxford

Oxford, Oct 2024 – present | Higher Education

Lead senior financial management across a complex academic department with £25.8m research income, £22.5m non-research income, and £172.5m in annual grant funding from 154 funding bodies, supporting strong financial control, decision-making, and service delivery.

- Lead the annual budgeting and quarterly forecasting process, partnering with 30+ budget holders and Principal Investigators and consolidating departmental submissions for the Medical Sciences Division.
- Deliver monthly management accounts, variance analysis, and financial commentary to budget holders, supporting timely decision-making. Design and automate the distribution of month-end reports to over 100 cost-centre and budget owners.
- Lead continuous improvement initiatives across financial processes using Lean principles, streamlining invoice processing and expense approvals, reducing invoice processing times by 15%, and enhancing departmental SOPs to strengthen financial controls, improve audit outcomes, and reduce audit queries.
- Support the financial planning and implementation of research facilities and strategic projects, developing business cases, financial models, and cost recovery frameworks to ensure auditable and sustainable funding. Use generative AI as a decision-support tool to explore scenarios and challenge assumptions when preparing five-year financial projections.
- Improve month-end processes and reporting timetables, reducing financial close and reporting cycles from 7 to 4 days and improving the timeliness of management information.
- Strengthen controls and compliance through SOP improvements, authorised signatory oversight, and maintenance of key departmental registers, including Financial Risk and Gift & Hospitality.
- Introduce practical AI and digital solutions within the team, including tools for contract interpretation, staff onboarding, and budget-holder understanding of monthly results and expense policies, and create a month-end control tower to strengthen oversight, accountability, and coordination across the close cycle.
- Lead monthly payroll variance and FTE analysis across an annual payroll cost base of £9m, providing clear insight into staffing costs, vacancy management, and workforce trends.

- Co-manage and develop the finance team, overseeing recruitment, training, performance, and workload planning to improve resilience and service delivery.
- Act as a key liaison with divisional finance, central finance, governance teams, auditors, and external stakeholders, resolving complex issues and presenting financial matters clearly to non-financial audiences.

Finance Business Partner | AT The Bus

Oxford, Dec 2021 – Sep 2024 | Non-profit (part-time)

Led the charity's finance function on a standalone basis, overseeing governance, budgeting, forecasting, reporting, payroll, and fundraising finance, while ensuring compliance with Charities SORP and Charity Commission requirements.

- Partnered closely with the CEO and Team Leaders to develop annual budgets and forecasts aligned with organisational priorities and funding requirements. Created bespoke Xero budget reports.
- Produced management reporting, variance analysis, and KPI insights for the CEO and Trustees, supporting effective oversight and decision-making.
- Strengthened financial control and stewardship by ensuring resources were spent and managed in line with charity policy, legal requirements, and funder restrictions.
- Designed tailored reports to assess fundraising performance, track restricted funds, and improve visibility of programme and grant-related expenditure.
- Supported grant applications, audit and funder reporting by providing accurate, decision-useful financial information and bespoke reporting.

Finance Business Partner | Tamesis Partnership Ltd

Oxford, Apr 2014 – Apr 2023 | Accounting & Finance Consultancy

Founded and developed a specialist finance consultancy supporting owner-managed manufacturing and retail businesses with annual turnover of £250k–£5m, providing financial leadership, reporting, process improvement, systems implementation, and digital transformation support.

- Partnered with business owners and senior leaders to improve financial visibility, strengthen governance, and support better operational and commercial decision-making.
- Delivered management accounts, year-end reporting, bespoke financial reports, KPI tracking, and budgeting and forecasting support tailored to individual business needs.
- Designed industry-specific reporting and explained financial performance clearly to non-financial stakeholders, improving understanding of risks, trends, and business performance.
- Led finance process improvements and created bespoke accounting procedures aligned with HMRC requirements, reducing compliance risk and avoiding penalties.
- Implemented accounting systems, managed data migrations, and introduced app integrations to improve efficiency, reporting quality, and financial control.
- Trained senior leaders and finance staff on accounting software and financial tools, improving capability, confidence, and day-to-day use of systems.
- Recruited, managed, and developed finance team members, including bookkeepers and an accountant, supporting service quality and team effectiveness.

Associate Director of Finance | Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group

London, Jun11 – Mar14 | Financial Services

Oversaw the financial operations of the bank's UK rail leasing division, supporting financial control, investment analysis, and reporting in alignment with the requirements of the US parent company. Managed reporting and analysis across a £15m turnover business and a £126m asset base.

- Led management accounts, reporting packs, and variance analysis, providing clear financial insight to senior stakeholders in both the UK and the US.
- Supported investment and leasing decisions through pricing analysis and financial evaluation of new equipment acquisitions and leasing opportunities.
- Managed accounting and reporting for a £126m asset base, including CAPEX and maintenance cost analysis to improve asset performance tracking and financial accuracy.

- Coordinated lease-related accounting matters with the Boston office, including funding arrangements, lease amendments, and lessee delinquencies.
- Oversaw UK regulatory and compliance reporting, including VAT, EC Sales List, and Intrastat, and supported internal and external audits through the preparation of audit packs and detailed financial information.
- Supported the group CFO's budgeting and forecasting processes through financial modelling, analysis, and ad hoc reporting for Head Office.

Management Accountant | iMC Group

London, Aug 2009 – May 2011 | Online Audio and Video Media

Managed accounting activities in a fast-growing start-up environment, establishing robust financial processes and delivering reporting to support senior leadership and investor decision-making.

- Delivered monthly management accounts, consolidated reporting, and KPI analysis to support strategic and commercial decisions.
- Led preparation of year-end audit packs and statutory accounts for UK and Isle of Man entities.
- Supported budgeting, forecasting, and multi-jurisdictional reporting, including UK and Luxembourg GAAP adjustments.

Management Accountant | SThree Plc

London, Aug 2007 – Aug 2009 | Recruitment

Produced management accounts and budgeting support across five legal entities within a multinational recruitment plc, delivering timely reporting and analysis to support financial control and business performance.

- Performed monthly variance analysis and ad hoc reporting to provide insight to the Financial Controller and senior stakeholders.
- Maintained balance sheet integrity through reconciliations, journals, fixed asset accounting, and intercompany controls, while supporting audit and continuous improvement activity.

Operational Accountant | Avanta Serviced Office Group

London, Jul 2006 – Jul 2007 (contract) | Serviced Offices

Supported the reorganisation of the finance function during a period of expansion, improving procedures, controls, and team effectiveness across multiple operational entities.

- Prepared and reviewed monthly management accounts and strengthened cash flow oversight through sales and purchase ledger review.
- Managed and developed the accounts payable team, improving service quality and reducing invoice processing time by 25%.

Management Accountant | Levi Strauss & Co UK

London, Apr 2005 – Jun 2006 (contract) | Retail

Led accounting for the UK shoe and accessories division, delivering accurate monthly reporting and supporting process and control improvements within the UK business.

- Managed day-to-day accounting, cash management, and regulatory reporting, including VAT, EC Sales Lists, and Intrastat.
- Prepared management accounts and group reporting packs, while working with the Finance Controller to improve processes and reporting controls.

Finance & Office Manager | Group EULEN (Spain)

Lisbon, Sep02 to Mar05 | Security, Recruitment & Cleaning Services

Managed finance and office operations for the group's companies in Portugal, supporting departmental reorganisation, systems change, financial reporting, and team development in a cross-border environment.

- Led finance process redesign and staff training during the transition from AS400 to SAP R/3.
- Prepared management accounts, group reporting packs, and balance sheet reviews, while supporting decision-making for senior leaders and coordinating with stakeholders in Portugal and Spain.

EDUCATION

Studying towards **CIMA** qualification

Master's-level degree in Business Administration
(Licenciatura) Instituto Superior de Gestão, 1995–2000, Lisbon

Cert. in **Business Accounting**
CIMA, 2008, London

Certified Bookkeeper
ICB, 2014–2015, London

OTHER

Courses:

Essentials of Leading Strategic Projects, *Saïd Business School, Apr 2026*

The Confident Manager Series, *Oxford University, Oct 2025*

Certifications:

Xero Adviser Certified (*since 2014*)

Xero Migration Certified

Volunteer Experience:

Treasurer – Headington Rye Oxford Parent's Association (*since Jan 2026*)

Trustee & Head of project to set up local non-profit preschool (*2020-2023*)

Created a networking group in Oxfordshire for mums in business (*2017–2020*)